SMOKED BISON RIB-EYE
WITH PLAINS CHIMICHURRI

serves 2 to 4

Bison steaks tend to be quite lean, so it's best to cook them to medium-rare. At Owamni, we prepare these steaks in a three-step process. First, we dry-brine them in a mixture of salt, maple sugar, and a bit of chile. Then we smoke them to infuse them with more flavor and to slowly bring them up to doneness. Finally, we sear them just before serving.

We tend to prefer oak for smoking the steaks, because it allows the flavor of the meat to shine through. You can also use hickory wood, which will bring a more intense smokiness, or a fruitwood, like apple or cherry, which will bring a delicate sweetness.

If you don't have a smoker, you can set up your grill for indirect cooking (see Smoking Food on a Grill, page 69, starting the steaks at a low temperature and then finishing them off with a sear. Inspired by the traditional Argentinian sauce, I make a chimichurri using wild herbs as well as the usual garlic, vinegar, and oil. It's beautiful with the rich flavor of meats, including bison.

Make the rib-eye: In a small bowl, mix together the maple sugar, both salts, and ancho powder. Rub the mixture all over the meat and refrigerate uncovered for at least 4 hours and up to 24 hours.

Preheat a smoker to 250°F (or if you don't have a smoker, see Smoking Food on a Grill, page 69).

Pat the meat dry, insert a probe thermometer into the thickest part of the steaks, and smoke for 10 to 15 minutes, until the internal temperature is 100° to 105°F. Transfer to a plate.

Heat a cast-iron skillet, grill pan, or outdoor grill over high heat. If you're using a skillet or grill pan, add the oil and heat until shimmering. Otherwise, oil the grates. Add the steaks and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until nicely seared on the bottom. Flip and cook until nicely seared on the other side.

Insert a thermometer into the center part of the steak. If it registers between 120° and 125°F, transfer the meat to a carving board and let rest for 5 minutes. Otherwise, reduce the heat to medium-low and continue cooking, turning the steaks occasionally, until they reach the proper temperature.

Make the chimichurri: In a blender or mini food processor, coarsely chop the wild greens, herbs, and garlic. Add the vinegar and pepper flakes and process until the greens and garlic are finely chopped. Season with salt. Transfer to a bowl, then stir in the oil. Let the chimichurri stand for 10 minutes before serving. You can refrigerate the chimichurri in an airtight container overnight.

After the meat rests, thinly slice it crosswise. Serve with the chimichurri and garnish with the scallions and berries.

RIB-EYE

- 2 tablespoons Maple Sugar (page 36) or store-bought
- 1½ tablespoons coarse sea salt
- ½ tablespoon smoked salt (or more sea salt)
- 1½ teaspoons ancho chile powder
- 2 bison rib-eye steaks, each about 1½ inches thick
- 1 tablespoon sunflower oil

CHIMICHURRI

- ½ cup wild greens, such as wild parsley, lamb's quarters, amaranth greens, or common plantain
- 2 tablespoons fresh anise hyssop or wild mint leaves
- 4 stalks wild garlic or 4 large garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tablespoons cider vinegar
- 1 teaspoon red pepper flakes
- Sea salt
- ½ cup sunflower oil

GARNISH

- Thinly sliced scallions
- Handful of local berries